

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

This is thought of as a kind of place of purification, in which sins not forgiven in one's life on earth might be forgiven.

However, on closer inspection, this Catholic doctrine is less helpful in the present context than you might think.

Here is a statement of the doctrine from the Catechism:

1030 All who die in God's grace and friendship, but still imperfectly purified, are indeed assured of their eternal salvation; but after death they undergo purification, so as to achieve the holiness necessary to enter the joy of heaven.

1031 The Church gives the name Purgatory to this final purification of the elect, which is entirely different from the punishment of the damned.



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replies to the
paradox



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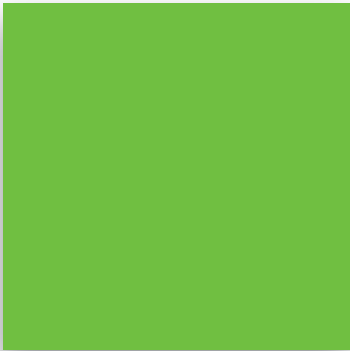
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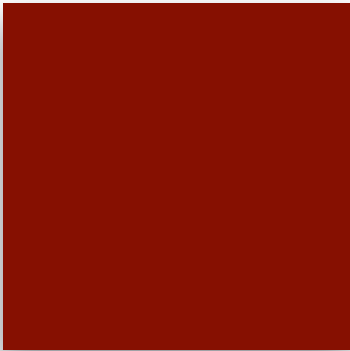












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to achieve the highest nearest neighbor to the joy heard

principle that their direct, which is directly different from

imperfectly provided, are indeed as if their real

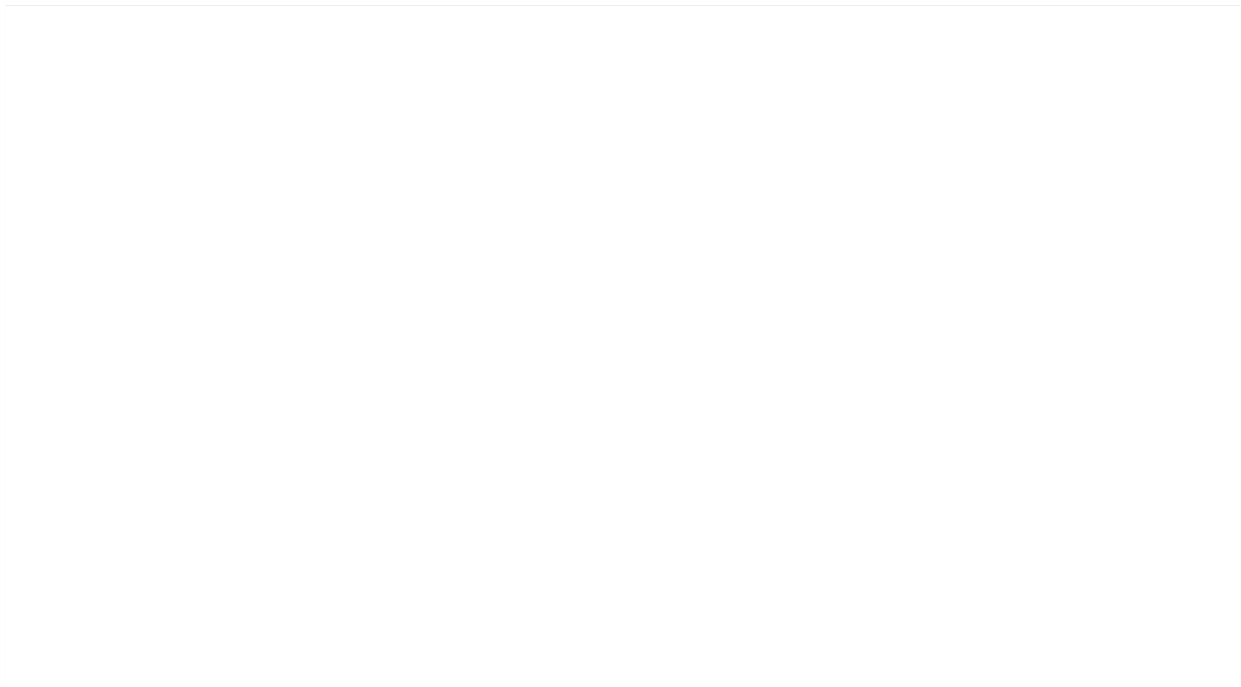
all over; but after death they were put in a box, as

1031 The Church gives the name Purgatory to this fire.

the principle of the damped.

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:

The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church



1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

eternity!

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

into external punishment, but the rights into

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by



right hand, but the goat at the left... and

this glory, and all the angels with him.

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

and the wild sheep are then from another

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

but the rights are all in it.

they will go away into eternal punishment,

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?











evil & lives
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living

Badness

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control

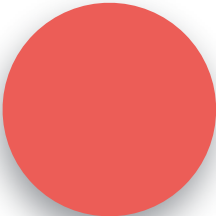
Justice

It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.

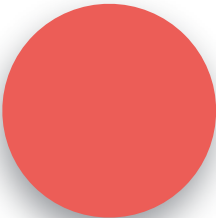


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